

Sujin Lee

lee.9962@osu.edu ◇ (614) 736-8079

410 Arps Hall, 1945 N High Street, Columbus, OH 43210

Research Interests

Labor Economics, Entrepreneurship

Education

The Ohio State University, Ph.D., Economics	2021-2027 (expected)
Seoul National University, M.A., Economics	2019-2021
Seoul National University, B.A., Economics	2015-2019

Working Papers

- “Jack-of-All-Trades or Jack-of-Business-Trades? The Importance of Business Skills in Different Types of Self-Employment”

Abstract: Lazear’s (2004, 2005) jack-of-all-trades (JOAT) hypothesis suggests that skill diversity is a key driver of entrepreneurial entry and success. This idea has led to extensive empirical investigation that often uses occupation or employer counts to measure skill diversity and self-employment to proxy entrepreneurship. In this paper, I revisit the JOAT hypothesis by arguing that workers need not be jacks of “all” trades to succeed in business; they simply need a combination of specialized skills and business skills. In addition, I argue that the importance of a worker’s skill mix is likely to differ for small, simple (often unincorporated and low-skill) businesses versus larger, more complex businesses. To test this, I construct a novel measure of business skill by linking near-complete work histories from NLSY79 data to O*NET data, creating a time-in-occupation-weighted measure of the occupation-specific importance of managerial and people skills. I then examine how these skills influence both the probability of transitioning into different types of self-employment and subsequent success, measured by earnings and business longevity. My findings indicate that business skills are particularly important for entry into and success in complex self-employment, while conventional measures of skill diversity (occupation and employer counts) predict entry into simple self-employment. These results imply that targeted skill development in business-specific areas is more beneficial for success in complex businesses than broadly increasing skill diversity across unrelated domains.

- “Restricting Large Retailers: Evidence from South Korea” (with Marco Gonzalez-Navarro and Jaecheol Lee), *Submitted*.

Abstract: Regulations that restrict the operating days of large firms are often justified as a means of protecting small competitors. We study South Korea’s mandatory shutdown policy, which requires large retail chains to close one day every other week, and quantify how consumer spending adjusts along multiple margins. Using high-frequency transaction data and exploiting within-month variation in closure schedules, we document four substitution channels: diversion to independent retailers, substitution toward other unrestricted retail formats, intertemporal shifting within restricted chains, and spatial substitution across districts with different closure calendars. Only a small share of displaced spending is redirected to independent retailers, while most adjustment occurs through intertemporal substitution within restricted chains and diversion to other unrestricted retail formats operated by large chains. We find no evidence that the policy improves the long-run survival of independent retailers. Mapping observed substitution patterns into a discrete-choice framework, we estimate that consumer welfare losses

from restricted access exceed the gains accruing to small retailers by a factor of 2.6, highlighting a fundamental trade-off inherent in protective regulation.

Work in Progress

- “Long-Term Effects of Financial Education in High School on Business Ownership”

Abstract: Financial illiteracy is widespread, particularly among women and those with less education (Lusardi and Mitchell, 2023). These groups are less likely to own businesses, and when they do, their businesses tend to be smaller, simpler, and less reliant on external financing – potentially due to constraints like limited access to credit or financial decision-making challenges stemming from a lack of financial knowledge. If financial illiteracy is a constraint, mandatory financial education during high school could increase business activity and improve business outcomes for these groups. Previous research suggests that high school financial education improves short-term outcomes, such as financial knowledge and behaviors related to saving, debt, and debt repayment in early adulthood. In this paper, I contribute to the literature by examining the differential long-term effects on business outcomes for women and those with less education. Using SIPP data, I assess whether mandatory financial education increases the likelihood of being self-employed, enhances the value of businesses owned or business income, and increases the likelihood of business entry in finance-intensive industries, with particular attention to differences across gender and educational attainment.

- “Can Self-Employment Provide a Lifeline for Struggling Workers?”

Abstract: Public policies often promote self-employment among individuals receiving government support, such as unemployment benefits, with the hope that it serves as a viable pathway to improved career outcomes. In this paper, I examine the effectiveness of self-employment in enhancing career outcomes for individuals facing labor market hardship, such as low wages, limited wage growth, employment instability, and reliance on public assistance. Using data from the NLSY79, I investigate whether transitioning into self-employment after a period of hardship leads to higher wages, wage growth, better employment stability, wealth accumulation, and reduced dependence on public assistance programs – including unemployment insurance, food stamps, and other welfare benefits – both during and after self-employment. To address selection bias, I use matching methods to compare individuals who enter self-employment with those who do not. This analysis offers valuable insights into the potential role of self-employment as a policy tool for individuals facing labor market challenges.

- “AI in Higher Education” (with Tian Lou, Aiday Sikhova, Harrison Youn, and Bruce Weinberg)
- “AI Adoption and Gender Disparities in the Workforce” (with Tian Lou and Bruce Weinberg)

Abstract: How does a business’s exposure to AI influence gender disparities in its workforce? Building on the idea that AI technology is transmitted through human capital, we track AI-trained researchers to examine gender composition and wage gaps at firms that hire these researchers compared to those hiring researchers in non-AI fields within the same narrowly defined industries. Using UMETRICS data, which track payment records for all university research employees on grants, linked with Elsevier data on AI-publishing authors, we measure a grant’s “AI intensity” based on the AI publication activity of its principal investigators and an employee’s “AI exposure” based on their duration and intensity of work on these AI-related grants. We then follow these researchers into the workforce using Ohio UI Wage Records and the Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages to identify businesses that are more likely to have adopted advanced AI by hiring AI-trained researchers. We find that firms hiring AI-trained researchers have a lower share of female employees and wider gender pay gaps, even among non-AI-trained workers, compared to other firms in the same industries that do not hire AI-trained researchers. We also find a

clear gradient based on how many AI-trained researchers firms hired as well as how much “AI exposure” AI-trained researchers had. These suggest that AI adoption can influence gender disparities across the broader workforce, beyond AI researchers and those directly involved in AI development or use.

Pre-Doctoral Publications

- “The Effect of COVID-19 Stimulus Payments on Household Spending” (with Chulhee Lee), *Korean Journal of Social Policy*, 51, 2022, 60-88 (in Korean, non-peer reviewed).
- “The Effect of Child Support Payment Coupons in Response to COVID-19 on Household Spending” (with Chulhee Lee), *The Korean Journal of Economic Studies*, 69(3), 2021, 5-54 (in Korean).

Scholarships

University Fellowship, The Ohio State University, 2021-2022

Graduate Student Instructor Fellowship, Seoul National University, 2019-2021

Relevant Positions

Research Assistant to Professor Bruce Weinberg, The Ohio State University, SP 2024-present

Research Assistant to Professor Chulhee Lee, Seoul National University, SP 2019-SU 2021

Research Assistant to Professor Jisoo Hwang, Seoul National University, SP 2020-SU 2021

Research Assistant to Professor Sok Chul Hong, Seoul National University, FA 2020-SP 2021

Teaching Experience

Independent Instructor at The Ohio State University

Principles of Microeconomics (SU 2023)

Teaching Assistant at The Ohio State University

Principles of Microeconomics (FA 2023), Principles of Macroeconomics (FA 2023), Health Economics (FA 2022), Intermediate Microeconomic Theory with Calculus (FA 2022)

Teaching Assistant at Seoul National University

Population and Economy (FA 2019, FA 2020), Economic History (SP 2020)

Conference Presentations

2025 Southern Economic Association (Tampa)

2023 Decision Sciences Collaborative Spring Forum Poster Session (OSU), North American Meetings of the Urban Economics Association (U Toronto), BGSU/OSU Graduate Student Conference on Population (OSU)

2020 Society for the Advancement of Socio-Economics Conference (virtual)

Last updated: February 21, 2026